



Firm Foundations

The motherboard... an oft-neglected component, it nevertheless fields all your hardware and dictates the extent of your next upgrade. Spend the most time choosing the right one, because chances are it'll be residing inside that cabinet longer than most!

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Motherboards do not bask in the limelight the way CPUs and graphics cards do, despite their obvious importance. Simply put, your motherboard is a meeting ground for all your hardware. Thankfully, perceptions have evolved, and a motherboard is no longer just a large PCB that you plonk your CPU on to. A quick look at some of the boards in the following test will reinforce this point.

The sheer number of features that are crammed into high-end boards is amazing, and the good news is, motherboards are offering great value for money, thanks to falling prices. Manufacturers have also understood their markets better, and boards based on the latest chipsets no longer no longer command the premium they once did! Manufacturers have realised the need to target segments, and make sure the latest technologies

are available to all price segments—so you can get affordable high-performance chipsets, albeit with lower feature counts!

That said, motherboards still aren't first priority, and your purchase decision is based solely on the CPU you choose. For example, an AMD AM2 processor obviously needs an AM2-based motherboard, and so on. The good news is there's a plethora of options out there even after fixing on a particular class of processor—not only manufacturer options, but chipset options as well. Finding motherboards that suit your needs is easy; choosing the right one, however, will be a royal pain! That's where we come in...

The first distinction you have to make is choosing between an Intel and AMD processor. Now the plot thickens. You have five options when it comes to chipsets—Intel, ATI, NVIDIA, SiS and VIA, the first three names being the bigger manufacturers.

So as not to confuse you, we've decided to serve you the motherboards we received in two different courses, and since "A" comes before "I", we'll take a look at all the AMD-based motherboards first.

MOTHERBOARDS FOR THE AMD PLATFORM

Socket AM2 (940-pin)

As mentioned, all newer AMD processors come on a 940-pin, AM2 socket configuration. Don't confuse these 940-pin processors from AMD's earlier server range of processors—the Opterons—which supported DDR memory and also had 940 pins. They're incompatible with socket AM2.

AM2 motherboards support the entire Athlon AM2 processor line, from the humble 3600+ to the fiery FX-62; no need of any BIOS updates at all! NVIDIA is once again at the forefront for the AMD platform, and their nForce 5 series of motherboards are to the AM2 processors what nForce 4 was to the Socket 939 processors.